

BHAKTIVEDANTA INSTITUTE FOR HIGHER STUDIES

Where Science and Philosophy Meet

ACADEMIC CATALOG

Fall Quarter 2026 | Academic Year 2026–2027

A 501(c)(3) Nonprofit Educational Institution

bihs.org

1. Institutional Overview

Mission Statement

The Bhaktivedanta Institute for Higher Studies (BIHS) is a nonprofit educational institution dedicated to the rigorous academic exploration of consciousness, philosophy, and history. BIHS advances an integrative intellectual framework that places the study of consciousness at the center of human inquiry, drawing on the Vedic philosophical tradition in dialogue with contemporary science, philosophy of mind, cosmology, and the humanities.

Our mission is to offer academically rigorous instruction that equips students with the conceptual tools, critical thinking skills, and scholarly foundation necessary to engage meaningfully with questions of consciousness, existence, and meaning in modern scientific and intellectual contexts.

Vision

BIHS envisions a future in which the study of consciousness is recognized as a foundational discipline — one that integrates the insights of ancient philosophical traditions with the methods of modern science. We seek to become a nationally recognized institution offering accredited degrees in Consciousness Studies, Philosophy of Science, and History.

Institutional Identity

Legal Name	Bhaktivedanta Institute for Higher Studies
Tax Status	501(c)(3) Nonprofit Corporation
Primary Mode	Online — Live Video (Zoom) + Canvas LMS
Academic Calendar	Quarter System (10-week terms)
Language of Instruction	English
Website	bihstudies.org

Institutional History

The Bhaktivedanta Institute for Higher Studies was established as a nonprofit educational organization dedicated to the rigorous academic exploration of consciousness, science, philosophy, and history. BIHS is headquartered in Gainesville, Florida, home to one of the nation's leading research universities, in a historic property that once served as the residence of a former president of the University of Florida. The Institute maintains a research library of more than 6,000 volumes spanning science, philosophy, theology, Vedic wisdom, and history.

BIHS has been engaged in academic programming since 2019, when it organized its first international conference on the science of consciousness. Over the following years, BIHS convened two additional in-person and online conferences focused on cosmology and evolution respectively, each drawing between 50 and 100 participants from the scholarly and research community. These gatherings established BIHS as a recognized convener of rigorous interdisciplinary dialogue at the intersection of science, philosophy, and Vedic thought.

In 2024, BIHS expanded its programming with its first structured academic series, attracting approximately 400 participants online.

In Summer 2025, BIHS organized the Summer Discovery Series — a free three-weekend international online symposium featuring 19 distinguished scholars exploring consciousness, ethics, cosmology, and philosophy of science. The series attracted over 300 participants from around the world, demonstrating both the demand for rigorous interdisciplinary dialogue and BIHS's capacity to deliver it at an international level.

In Spring 2026, BIHS launched its pilot program **Consciousness Studies: Ancient and Modern Perspectives** — a 24-week university-style program currently underway, delivered through Canvas, BIHS's learning management system, and weekly live Zoom sessions. The program has demonstrated BIHS's academic operational capacity across five key areas: structured curriculum design, doctoral faculty instruction, formal student assessment, learning management system administration, and certificate award. The program has enrolled 181 participants, 60 of whom are receiving scholarship support through the BIHS Community Scholarship Fund. Faculty hold doctoral degrees in relevant fields and bring international scholarly recognition to their respective units. Each unit concludes with a formal assessment, and students who successfully complete all unit requirements and a final examination receive both individual Unit Certificates and a Final Program Certificate of Completion documenting demonstrated mastery in Vedic Cosmology, Philosophy Foundations, Foundations of Metaphysics, Physics and Cosmology, and Consciousness Studies.

Fall Quarter 2026 marks BIHS's first formal academic term, offering three structured courses in Biology and Consciousness, History of the Vaishnava Tradition in the West, and Introduction to Philosophy. Each course is designed to university standards, runs 10 weeks, meets three hours per week, and is taught by doctoral faculty. This milestone represents the culmination of seven years of academic community building and the beginning of BIHS's journey toward full institutional accreditation

2. Academic Standards and Policies

Credit Hour Definition

BIHS defines one (1) semester credit hour in accordance with the Carnegie Unit standard and the U.S. Department of Education federal definition (34 CFR § 600.2). One credit hour represents a minimum of:

- 15 hours of direct faculty instruction (contact hours), plus
- 30 hours of out-of-class student academic work (reading, assignments, assessments)
- Total: approximately 45 student work hours per credit

A 3-credit course at BIHS therefore requires 3 contact hours per week across a 10-week term (30 total contact hours) and approximately 60 additional hours of student engagement, for a total of approximately 90 student hours per course. This standard applies to all synchronous online instruction delivered via Zoom and supported by asynchronous Canvas course modules.

Grading and Assessment

BIHS employs criterion-referenced assessment aligned to stated Student Learning Outcomes for each course. The following grading scale applies to all BIHS academic courses:

A (90–100%)	Exceptional mastery of course learning outcomes
B (80–89%)	Solid mastery with minor gaps
C (70–79%)	Adequate mastery; meets minimum standards
D (60–69%)	Partial mastery; does not meet program standards
F (Below 60%)	Insufficient mastery; course must be repeated for credit

A minimum grade of C is required to receive course credit. Students who do not achieve a passing grade may retake the course in a subsequent term.

Attendance and Participation

Regular attendance at live Zoom sessions is expected. Students may miss no more than two (2) class sessions per 10-week course without academic penalty. Students who exceed this limit will be required to complete a documented make-up assignment approved by the instructor. All live sessions are recorded and made available on Canvas within 48 hours for asynchronous review.

Academic Integrity

BIHS is committed to the highest standards of academic honesty. All submitted work must represent the student's own intellectual effort. Plagiarism, fabrication, or misrepresentation of sources will result in a failing grade for the assignment and may result in dismissal from the course. Students are required to cite all sources using a consistent academic citation style (Chicago, MLA, or APA, as designated by the instructor).

Satisfactory Academic Progress

Students must maintain a cumulative GPA of 2.0 (C average) or above to remain in good academic standing. Students falling below this threshold will be placed on academic probation and may access tutoring support and faculty advising. Continued enrollment is contingent on a demonstrated improvement plan.

3. Admissions and Enrollment

Admissions Requirements

BIHS welcomes students who seek rigorous academic engagement with questions of consciousness, science, philosophy, and history. BIHS does not discriminate on the basis of race, color, national origin, gender, age, disability, or religious affiliation.

To enroll in BIHS academic courses, applicants must:

- Hold a high school diploma or equivalent (GED or international equivalent)
- Submit a completed enrollment application
- Demonstrate basic written English proficiency
- Agree to BIHS's Student Code of Conduct and Academic Integrity Policy

Non-Credit and Audit Enrollment

Students may enroll in courses on a non-credit or audit basis. Non-credit participants receive a Certificate of Completion upon satisfactory participation but do not earn academic credit. Audit students attend sessions without submitting graded assessments.

Tuition and Fees — Fall Quarter 2026

Tuition — Standard Rate (per course)	\$300
Tuition — Community Rate (per course)	\$150
Full Term — Standard (3 courses)	\$750
Full Term — Community Rate (3 courses)	\$375
Non-Credit / Audit (3 courses)	\$108

Additional fees: Application Fee \$0 (waived for Fall 2026) | Technology Fee: Included in tuition.

The Community Rate is available to members of the BIHS congregation and affiliated Vaishnava communities. Scholarship assistance is also available through the BIHS Community Scholarship Fund for students demonstrating financial need.

BIHS Community Scholarship Fund

BIHS is committed to making rigorous education accessible to all members of its community. The BIHS Community Scholarship Fund provides partial or full tuition scholarships to students who demonstrate financial need or community service. Scholarship recipients are determined by the BIHS Admissions Committee on a rolling basis.

To apply for scholarship consideration, students must submit a brief written statement (200–400 words) describing their academic goals and the nature of their financial need or community contribution. Scholarship decisions are made within 10 business days of application.

In the Spring 2026 pilot program, 60 of 181 enrolled participants received scholarship support — a 33% scholarship rate that BIHS is committed to sustaining in its formal academic programs.

Refund Policy

Students who withdraw from a course prior to the start of Week 3 will receive a 100% tuition refund. Students who withdraw during Weeks 3–4 will receive a 50% refund. No refund is issued for withdrawals after Week 4. Students who experience documented medical or family emergencies may petition for a full or partial refund at any time during the term.

4. Institutional History: Spring 2026 Pilot Program

The following program was offered as a pilot in Spring–Summer 2026. It constitutes BIHS’s inaugural operational history and served as the foundation for the formal academic curriculum launched in Fall Quarter 2026. This record is preserved in the institutional catalog as documentation of BIHS’s demonstrated capacity to deliver university-style instruction, assess student performance, and award certificates of completion.

Consciousness Studies: Ancient and Modern Perspectives

Spring–Summer 2026 | 24-Week Pilot Program | Certificate of Completion

Format	Live Zoom (weekly Saturdays, 10:00 AM EST) + Canvas LMS
Duration	24 weeks (Spring: 16 weeks, Summer: 8 weeks)
Total Contact Hours	Approx. 72 hours
Enrollment	181 participants
Scholarship Recipients	60 participants (33%)
Assessment	Unit assessments + Final Program examination
Certification	Unit Certificate (per module) + Final Program Certificate
Tuition	\$108 full program; \$30 per unit
LMS Platform	Canvas (Instructure)

Pilot Curriculum — Six Units

Unit 1: Vedic Cosmology (4 weeks) — Dr. Tiziano Valentinuzzi

- Crisis of meaning: how physicalism fails to satisfy human purpose
- Consciousness-based universe: Atma-centered worldview vs. neuroscience and panpsychism
- The simulation hypothesis: Vedic metaphysics through quantum physics and information theory
- Divine love scientifically: Bhakti as rational principle

Unit 2: Philosophy Foundations (4 weeks) — Shivanand Sharma, PhD Candidate

- Introduction to Critical Thinking: constructing and critiquing arguments
- Introduction to Philosophy of Science: the nature and scope of science
- Introduction to Philosophy of Religion: faith and reason
- Introduction to Philosophy of Consciousness: theories of consciousness and personal identity

Unit 3: Foundations of Metaphysics (4 weeks) — Dr. Howard Resnick

- Epistemology: the foundations of knowing; the Bhagavad-gita's philosophy of knowledge
- Transcending philosophy's dark age: applied vs. theoretical science
- Natural law, natural rights, and objective morality
- Limits of physicalist accounts of ethics and normativity

Unit 4: Physics and Cosmology (4 weeks) — Dr. Doug Watson

- Crisis in modern physics: conceptual limitations
- Rethinking space, time, and matter: quantum mechanics
- Quantum gravity: reality as a universe of relationships
- Relational cosmology integrating consciousness

Units 5–6: Consciousness Studies (8 weeks) — Akhandadhi Das

- The hard problem of consciousness
- Metaphysical foundations and consciousness-world interaction
- Earth's biological mysteries: scientific support for Puranic perspectives
- Consciousness-based universal structure and realms of free consciousness

5. Fall Quarter 2026 — Course Offerings

Beginning Fall Quarter 2026, BIHS offers three structured academic courses designed to university standards, each running 10 weeks and taught by doctoral faculty. Each course meets three hours per week and follows a rigorous curriculum with assignments and a final assessment. These courses are designed to be credit-bearing upon accreditation, and students who complete all requirements now will receive a BIHS Certificate of Completion. All courses are delivered via live Zoom instruction and the Canvas learning management system.

Term	Fall Quarter 2026
Start Date	September 2026 (exact date TBD)
End Date	November 2026 (10 weeks from start)
Delivery	Online — Live Zoom + Canvas LMS
Contact Hours per Course	3 hrs/week × 10 weeks = 30 hrs
Contact Hours per Course	3 hrs/week × 10 weeks = 30 hrs
Courses Offered	3 (see below)
Total Contact Hours per Term	90 hrs (3 courses × 30 hrs)

CONS 101 | Biology and Consciousness

Credits: 3 Credits

Duration: 10 Weeks

Format: Online — Live Zoom + Canvas LMS

Contact Hours: 3 hrs/week × 10 weeks = 30 hrs

Student Work Hours: ~60 hrs outside class

Total Student Hours: ~90 hrs

Course Description

This course examines the intersection of biological science and the study of consciousness, investigating how life at the cellular, organismal, and ecological levels relates to questions of awareness, sentience, and subjective experience. Students will critically evaluate materialist and non-materialist frameworks for understanding the origin of consciousness in living systems, drawing on contemporary neuroscience, philosophy of biology, and Vedic perspectives on life and awareness. Special attention is given to the “hard problem” of consciousness as it applies to biological organisms and to emerging scientific research that challenges reductionist accounts of mind and life.

Student Learning Outcomes

Upon successful completion, students will be able to:

1. Explain the central arguments in the materialist and non-materialist debate over the biological basis of consciousness
2. Analyze the “hard problem of consciousness” as formulated by Chalmers and evaluate competing philosophical responses
3. Compare contemporary neuroscientific accounts of awareness with Vedic philosophical frameworks regarding the relationship between the self and the body
4. Evaluate selected empirical research on consciousness, near-death experience, and anomalous biological phenomena using standard academic methods of source analysis

5. Construct a written argument presenting and defending a coherent position on a contested question in the biology of consciousness

Representative Topics

- The cell as the unit of life: structure, function, and the question of agency
- Consciousness in the animal kingdom: gradations of sentience and awareness
- Neuroscience of consciousness: neural correlates, binding problem, global workspace theory
- The hard problem: why physical processes may not explain subjective experience
- Panpsychism, emergence, and other non-reductive frameworks
- Vedic perspectives on jiva, prana, and consciousness in living systems
- Anomalous biological phenomena and their philosophical implications
- Contemporary research frontiers: plant cognition, collective intelligence, consciousness and death

Instructor: Dr. Nitika Parmar | *PhD — Biology / Philosophy of Biology*

HIST 101 | History of the Vaishnava Tradition in the West

Credits: 3 Credits

Duration: 10 Weeks

Format: Online — Live Zoom + Canvas LMS

Contact Hours: 3 hrs/week × 10 weeks = 30 hrs

Student Work Hours: ~60 hrs outside class

Total Student Hours: ~90 hrs

Course Description

This course traces the transmission, reception, and development of the Vaishnava philosophical and devotional tradition from its South Asian origins to its establishment as a global religious and intellectual movement in the twentieth and twenty-first centuries. Students will examine the historical, cultural, and intellectual contexts in which Vedic and Vaishnava ideas entered Western academic and popular discourse, with particular attention to the work of the Bhaktivedanta Institute and the global reach of the Gaudiya Vaishnava tradition. The course employs standard methods of historical and textual analysis and situates the Vaishnava tradition within broader histories of religion, philosophy, and intercultural exchange.

Student Learning Outcomes

Upon successful completion, students will be able to:

6. Identify and explain the principal historical phases of Vaishnava philosophical development from the Bhagavata Purana through Gaudiya Vaishnavism
7. Analyze primary and secondary historical sources using standard methods of historical criticism and textual analysis
8. Trace the intellectual and cultural pathways by which Vaishnava ideas entered Western philosophical and religious discourse in the nineteenth and twentieth centuries
9. Evaluate the contributions of key figures — including Swami Vivekananda, Bhaktivinoda Thakura, and A.C. Bhaktivedanta Swami Prabhupada — to the globalization of Vaishnava thought
10. Construct a research-based historical argument situating a specific aspect of the Vaishnava tradition within its broader intellectual context

Representative Topics

- Foundations: the Bhagavata Purana, the Alvars, and the development of Vaishnava theology
- Ramanuja, Madhva, and the philosophical schools of Vaishnavism
- The Bengal Renaissance: Chaitanya Mahaprabhu and Gaudiya Vaishnavism

- Nineteenth-century encounters: Orientalism, colonial scholarship, and Hindu reform
- Swami Vivekananda and the World Parliament of Religions (1893)
- Bhaktivinoda Thakura and early outreach to Western audiences
- A.C. Bhaktivedanta Swami Prabhupada: the founding of ISKCON and global dissemination
- The Bhaktivedanta Institute: science, philosophy, and academic engagement
- Contemporary Vaishnava communities and intellectual movements in the West
- Historiographical debates: authenticity, representation, and the study of new religious movements

Instructor: Dr. Angela Burt | *PhD — Religious Studies / South Asian History*

PHIL 101 | Introduction to Philosophy

Credits: 3 Credits

Duration: 10 Weeks

Format: Online — Live Zoom + Canvas LMS

Contact Hours: 3 hrs/week × 10 weeks = 30 hrs

Student Work Hours: ~60 hrs outside class

Total Student Hours: ~90 hrs

Course Description

This course provides a systematic introduction to the central questions, methods, and traditions of Western and Indian philosophy. Students will engage with primary philosophical texts and develop the skills of close reading, logical analysis, and structured argumentation that are foundational to all advanced philosophical inquiry. Topics include epistemology (the nature and limits of knowledge), metaphysics (the nature of reality and existence), ethics (the foundations of moral reasoning), and philosophy of mind (the relationship between consciousness and the physical world). The course emphasizes the development of students' own philosophical reasoning through regular written work and structured discussion.

Student Learning Outcomes

Upon successful completion, students will be able to:

11. Identify and explain the central questions of epistemology, metaphysics, ethics, and philosophy of mind as addressed by major philosophical traditions
12. Read and analyze primary philosophical texts, identifying core arguments, key distinctions, and implicit assumptions
13. Construct and evaluate philosophical arguments in written form, using standard methods of logical analysis
14. Compare Western and Indian philosophical approaches to foundational questions of knowledge, reality, and consciousness
15. Apply philosophical reasoning to contemporary questions at the intersection of science, ethics, and the study of mind

Representative Topics

- What is philosophy? The examined life, wonder, and the love of wisdom
- Epistemology I: rationalism and empiricism; Plato's theory of knowledge
- Epistemology II: skepticism, justification, and the limits of reason; Nyaya epistemology
- Metaphysics I: substance, identity, and persistence through time
- Metaphysics II: the problem of universals; Samkhya and Vedanta on ultimate reality
- Philosophy of mind: dualism, physicalism, functionalism, and the problem of consciousness
- Ethics I: consequentialism, deontology, and virtue ethics
- Ethics II: dharma, karma, and moral reasoning in Indian philosophy

- Philosophy of religion: arguments for and against the existence of God; the problem of evil
- Philosophy of science: what is scientific explanation? Demarcation, paradigms, and limits

Instructor: TBD — Faculty search in progress | *PhD in Philosophy required; specialization in Philosophy of Mind or Indian Philosophy preferred*

6. Faculty

Faculty Qualifications Policy

BIHS is committed to maintaining a faculty of qualified scholars whose academic credentials and professional expertise are commensurate with the courses they teach. All faculty teaching courses at BIHS must hold, at minimum, a doctoral degree (PhD or equivalent) in a field directly relevant to their course assignment, or a master's degree with substantial documented professional expertise in the relevant field.

Approximately 90% of BIHS instructional faculty hold doctoral degrees from accredited universities. Faculty are recognized scholars whose work spans multiple countries and academic traditions. Full faculty CVs are available upon request from the BIHS Academic Office.

Spring 2026 Pilot Faculty

Dr. Tiziano Valentinuzzi	PhD — Vedic Cosmology, Metaphysics, Philosophy of Consciousness
Dr. Howard Resnick	PhD — Metaphysics, Epistemology, Vaishnava Philosophy
Dr. Doug Watson	PhD — Physics, Cosmology, Philosophy of Science
Akhandadhi Das	Advanced study — Consciousness Studies, Vaishnava Philosophy
Shivanand Sharma	PhD Candidate — Philosophy, Critical Thinking, Philosophy of Religion

Fall 2026 Faculty (Assignments in Progress)

Dr. Nitika Parmar (PhD) has been confirmed as instructor for CONS 101: Biology and Consciousness. Dr. Angela Burt (PhD) has been confirmed as instructor for HIST 101: History of the Vaishnava Tradition in the West. The search for the PHIL 101 instructor is ongoing; the position requires a PhD in Philosophy with expertise in philosophy of mind or Indian philosophy.

7. Contact and Institutional Information

Institution	Bhaktivedanta Institute for Higher Studies
Tax Status	501(c)(3) Nonprofit Educational Corporation
Website	bihs.org
LMS Platform	Canvas (Instructure) — bihstudies.instructure.com
Catalog Year	2026–2027
Effective Date	Fall Quarter 2026

This catalog is effective for Fall Quarter 2026 and is subject to revision. BIHS reserves the right to modify course offerings, tuition, and academic policies. Students will be notified of material changes prior to the start of each term. The most current version of this catalog is available at bihstudies.org.